FROM POLITICAL AWARENESS TO NATIONHOOD

IDEA OF NATIONALISM SIR SYED'S LEGACY: POLITICAL ASPECTS OF THE ALIGARH MOVEMENT & FORMATION/ROLE OF ALL INDIA MUSLIM LEAGUE

CHAP 11& 12

BACKGROUND- THE TWO-NATION LENS

- **Sir Syed Ahmad Khan's Vision:**
  - Asserted since the 1867 Hindi-Urdu conflict that Hindus and Muslims were distinct nations
  - Stressed that the 1857 uprising occurred due to lack of communication between the British and Indian races
  - Argued parliamentary democracy would fail Muslims as they would be outnumbered four to one by the Hindu majority
  - Advised Muslims against joining the Indian National Congress, viewing it as representative only of the majority community

SIR SYED'S LEGACY LIVES ON

Sir Syed: the intellectual Father of Muslim Nationalism

- Tried to reverse Muslim decline through education
- Advocated peaceful coexistence with rights
- His **vision matured into Pakistan's ideological backbone**

RESURGENCE OF URDU-HINDI CONFLICT (1900)

- **Cultural setback:** in April 1900, the British introduced Hindi in the United Provinces (U.P.), following a ban on Urdu in Bihar
- **Urdu Defence Association:** formed on May 2, 1900, at Aligarh by nawab Mohsin Ul Mulk to protest the official displacement of Urdu
- **Political shift:** despite sir Syed's earlier advice to avoid politics, the "fierce Hindi-Urdu conflict" forced Muslims to organize politically to protect their identity
- **British reaction:** Lt. Governor sir Anthony McDonnell forced Mohsin ul Mulk to resign from the Urdu Defence Association, which further politicized the community
- Subsequently October 1901, a meeting of Muslim notables was called at the Lucknow residence of Hamid Ali Khan, where Mahomedan political association was formed

THE PARTITION OF BENGAL (1905)

- **Administrative division:** Viceroy Lord Curzon divided Bengal into west Bengal and "east Bengal and Assam" on October 16, 1905, to facilitate administration
- **Demographic change:** the division created a Muslim-majority province in the east, while west Bengal became predominantly Hindu

THE PARTITION OF BENGAL (1905)

- **Hindu Protest:** Significant opposition was organized by professional classes (lawyers, doctors, professors) at the Kali temple, fearing a loss of influence and income to new institutions in Dhaka
- **Violence and terrorism:** Agitation included the assassination of officials and numerous attempts to bomb or derail trains

THE SIMLA DEPUTATION (OCTOBER 1, 1906)

- **The delegation:** led by sir Aga Khan III, 35 prominent Muslims met viceroy lord Minto at his summer residence in Simla
- **The memorial:** argued that Muslims were a "large and distinct community" whose importance should be measured by their historical role, not just numbers
- **Core demands:**
  - **Separate electorates:** Muslim voters voting only for Muslim candidates.
  - **Weightage:** representation exceeding their population proportion (e.g., 20% representation for a 13% population)
  - **Employment:** a larger share in government and judicial services
  - **Aligarh university:** elevating Aligarh college to university status

OUTCOMES OF THE SIMLA DEPUTATION

- **Viceroy's response:** expressed "profound sympathy" but notably **did not formally accept any demands** or commit to concrete steps
- **Constitutional success:** the demand for separate electorates was eventually conceded by secretary of state lord Morley in 1909 after continued pressure from leaders like Syed Hasan Bilgrami and Syed Amir Ali
- **Historical significance:** this was the first time the British recognized the Muslims as a separate political entity, a crucial step toward the eventual demand for partition

FOUNDATION OF THE ALL-INDIA MUSLIM LEAGUE

- **Formation:** established on December 30, 1906, at Dhaka.
- **Internal dynamics:** two distinct groups of Muslim politicians emerged:
  - **Bengal group:** focused on preserving the partition of Bengal
  - **U.P. Group:** focused on constitutional safeguards and separate electorates
- **Political realization:** the resignation of 1st Lt. Governor of east Bengal- sir Bampflyde Fuller served as a "warning bell" that the British might yield to Hindu agitators, necessitating a formal political party

FOUNDATION OF THE ALL-INDIA MUSLIM LEAGUE

- Conservative section of Muslims led the Simla deputation, while the radical, that is the more revolutionary section of Muslims formed the AIML. The interests of both sections, (conservative led by Aga Khan III and nawab Mohsin ul Mulk, and the radical section led by nawab Viqar ul Mulk and nawab Saleem Ullah) were **similar but not identical**
- The Muslims of Bengal, led by Saleem Ullah, the nawab of Dacca (now dhaka) were concerned mainly that the partition of Bengal should not be undone. The leaders of the Simla deputation had made no direct mention of Bengal's partition. The Muslims from minority provinces were concerned mostly with separate electorates

MEMBERSHIP AND ELITE STRUCTURE (1906)

- **Elite nature:** the early league was an elite organization, not yet representative of the masses
- **Membership requirements:**
  - Limited to 400 members nationwide
  - Must be over 25 years old and literate in an Indian language.
  - Annual income must exceed Rs 500.
  - High entry fees and annual subscriptions (Rs 25 each).
- **Legacy:** these leaders utilized their "independent status" and western education (particularly as lawyers) to plead the Muslim cause in political arenas

AIMS AND OBJECTS OF THE AIML (1906)

- To promote among the Muslims of India a feeling of loyalty to the British government and to remove any misconceptions regarding the intentions of the government about its policies and measures
- To protect and advance the political rights and interests of the Muslims of India and to respectfully present their needs and aspirations to the government
- To prevent the rise of hostility among Muslims toward other communities without prejudice to the above objectives of the league

AIMS AND OBJECTS OF THE AIML (1912)

- To maintain and promote among the people of India feelings of loyalty to the British Crown
- To protect and advance the political and other rights of the Muslims of India
- Without detriment to the pre-going objectives, to attain under the aegis of the British Crown, a system of self-government suitable to India through constitutional means

ACTIVITY

- Annotate upon aims and objectives of the league as declared in1906 & 1912 (Pg69-70)

